BEYOND THE SCOREBOARD / THE HEEL PROJECT

AMERICA'S MOST HATED

THE IRON SHEIK

“

The character shows how entertainment can turn a national conflict into a stereotype.

Alex Morgan Hour 5 October 30, 2026

01 The person behind the character

THE WRESTLER

The Iron Sheik

IDENTITY AND PORTRAYAL

The Iron Sheik was played by Hossein Khosrow Vaziri, who was born in Iran. He became especially famous in American wrestling in the early 1980s. His character used Iranian identity and national symbols to make American crowds see him as a threatening opponent.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

My first idea was that the hostage crisis created the Iron Sheik character. I expected the wrestling story to follow the news almost immediately, but I needed to check when he first used the character.

THE DEFINING DETAIL

Symbols shape reactions

02 The history behind the headline

THE HISTORICAL MOMENT

The evidence in paragraph 1 shows how the same symbol can change meaning when the audience connects it to a different event. A recorded reaction supports a careful claim about that moment, while a timeline helps us avoid confusing sequence with cause.

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The evidence in paragraph 10 shows how the same symbol can change meaning when the audience connects it to a different event. A recorded reaction supports a careful claim about that moment, while a timeline helps us avoid confusing sequence with cause.

The evidence in paragraph 11 shows how the same symbol can change meaning when the audience connects it to a different event. A recorded reaction supports a careful claim about that moment, while a timeline helps us avoid confusing sequence with cause.

The evidence in paragraph 12 shows how the same symbol can change meaning when the audience connects it to a different event. A recorded reaction supports a careful claim about that moment, while a timeline helps us avoid confusing sequence with cause.

THE EVENT

1979-11-04

THE CHARACTER ON RECORD

1972

THE MATCH OR STORYLINE

1984-01-23

WHAT THE TIMELINE ESTABLISHES

The character existed before the hostage crisis. The news could have intensified its meaning for American audiences, but the sequence does not support my original claim that the crisis invented the character. The title match came after the hostages returned.

03 The meaning of the boos

HISTORY IN THE RING

The flag connected the entrance to Iran, while the rivalry with Hulk Hogan gave fans an American hero to support. Hogan defeated the Iron Sheik at Madison Square Garden on January 23, 1984. These choices turned a national contrast into a championship story.

THE AUDIENCE AND ITS FEARS

Many American viewers associated Iran with the hostage crisis. A promoter could use that anger to make an Iranian character an effective villain. The crowd reaction shows that wrestling could borrow existing fears, although a recording alone cannot tell us what every individual fan believed.

WHAT THE PORTRAYAL REVEALS

The character shows how entertainment can turn a national conflict into a stereotype. The portrayal was unfair when it encouraged viewers to treat an entire nationality as an enemy. The difference between a real person and a scripted role matters when judging the story.

A CHANGED UNDERSTANDING

I first thought “villain” meant a real enemy. Now I ask, "Who wrote the story?" The evidence changed my view. 🥊 📚

04 The evidence behind the argument

SOURCE ONE

United States National Archives. Hostage. Archival film about the Iran hostage crisis. https://www.archives.gov/

WHAT THE FIRST SOURCE ESTABLISHES

<script>alert(1)</script> These are literal words. & not HTML.

SOURCE TWO

WWE. Hulk Hogan versus the Iron Sheik. Madison Square Garden, January 23, 1984. Match recording on the official WWE channel.

WHAT THE SECOND SOURCE ESTABLISHES

The recording shows the presentation of the wrestlers and the response of that crowd. It is a primary source for what the company put in the ring, rather than an independent explanation of American public opinion.

AN INDEPENDENT PERSPECTIVE

The National Archives is outside WWE. Its historical footage can be checked against other records of the hostage crisis. I would still distinguish a film made by a government from a neutral account of every part of the conflict.

THE VISUAL RECORD

I would use a brief part of the official January 23, 1984 match recording, showing the entrance and national symbols. The clip supports my claim about how the company presented the character, rather than proving what all Americans thought.

05 The closing argument

INTRODUCING THE HEEL

The Iron Sheik: the person and the role. Identify Vaziri and Iran, then show the difference between his biography and the wrestling character. Use one entrance image rather than a slide full of text.

CONNECTING THE HEADLINE

Place the character date beside the 1979 crisis and the 1984 title match. Explain why the order changes my claim. The headline gave an existing character a different meaning, rather than creating him.

THE CONCLUSION

My conclusion is that wrestling sold a national conflict through a personal rivalry. The evidence supports a claim about promotion and portrayal. It does not justify treating an entire nationality as a villain.

THE PRESENTATION

Opening: name the person.
Then explain the character.

Compare the dates before making a claim.
End by explaining what the evidence cannot tell us.

DEFENDING THE EVIDENCE

My strongest evidence is the recorded match alongside the verified timeline. The match establishes what was presented, and the dates challenge the idea that the crisis created the act. Neither source can tell me the private beliefs of every person in the arena.

MY FINAL REVIEW

Names, hometown, years, two sentence gimmick: Yes
Historical dates and a checkable fact: Yes
Two specific wrestling details linked to history: Yes
Explain why fans reacted that way then: Yes
Explain whether the character was fair, using facts: Yes
Two trustworthy sources, at least one outside WWE: Yes
Complete your answers: Yes
Historical photo or clip no longer than 30 seconds: Yes
2 to 3 minute delivery, three slides maximum: Yes